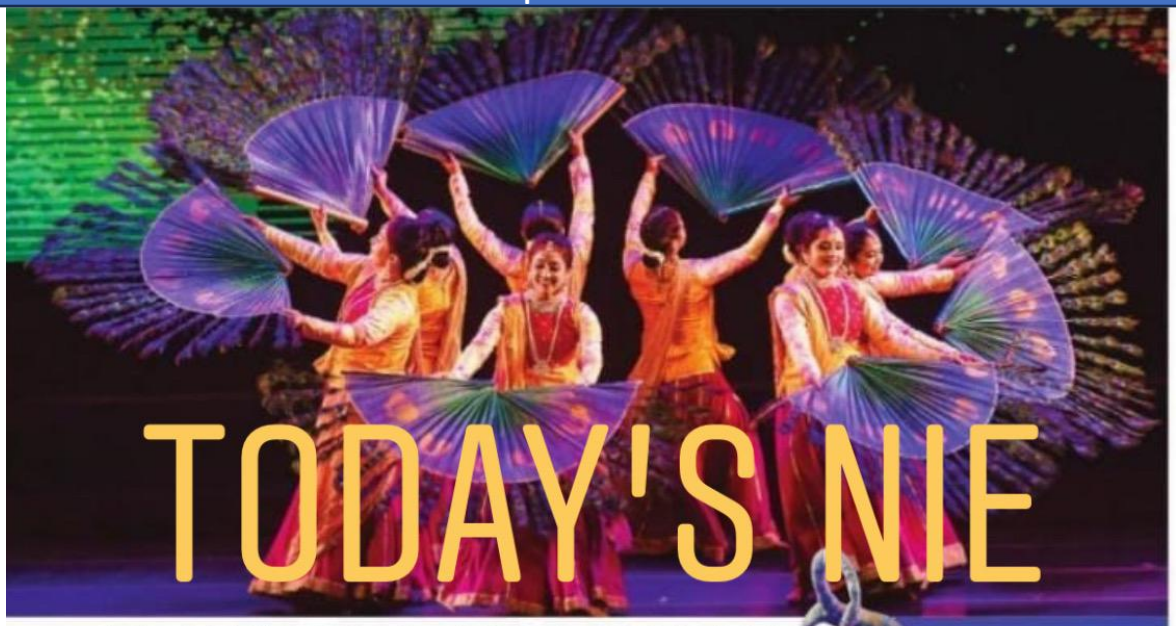


TODAY'S NIE

DANCE, DRAMA, DISNEY AND MORE

Abhinava Dance Company's *Rama Katha Vismaya* presented Ramayana through a musical, with elements of fantasy in it; 70 artistes were involved in its making

Express Features

Bengalureans got to witness the Ramayana like never before. Presented in a Disney-esque fashion, the production by city-based Abhinava Dance Company was staged in order to commemorate 25 years of their existence, and had 70 artistes on and off stage who helped out with it. The venue for the show, Chowdiah Memorial Hall was packed to the brim on Friday evening, the day it took place. "As a story, Ramayana is popular and connects with everyone. It also has multiple characters that make it interesting – Gods, celestial beings, demons, animals. Everyone's inner child likes to be entertained with a fantasy story, so we wanted to bring out the Ramayana as a fantasy musical," said Nirupama, who founded the company with Rajendra, while talking about Rama Katha Vismaya (RKV).

Told as a bedtime story by Yashoda to Krishna, the 90-minute show brought out iconic instances from the Indian epic – Sita's swayamvar, Ram fighting demons, their exile to the forest, chasing the golden deer, Ravan's kidnapping of Sita, Rama's homecoming – with eclectic choreography set to the lyrics penned by Shatavadhani Dr R Ganesh and music composed by Praveen D Rao. But besides the godly beings, this version of the story also had animals, plants, trees, birds and more coming to life on stage. Since Rajendra and Nirupama are both fans of animation, it comes as no surprise than Walt Disney has been an inspiration for them. "We have seen various Disney shows and animated films, so we wanted our show to also fall in the same entertaining category. And Walt Disney's characters are filled with emotions. So in RKV, we made every character come alive as well, besides using extensive props, lighting and costumes to make it similar to a Broadway musical," explained Nirupama, who played Yashoda and Shurpanakha in the play.

Rama Katha Vismaya marked day one of the company's three-day festival Parva, and was attended by dignitaries like former Chief Justice of India M N Venkatachaliah, Deputy Chief Minister of Karnataka Dr Ashwath Narayan CN, filmmaker Rajiv Menon and classical dancer Dr Padma Subrahmanyam. Choreographer Saroj Khan, who was also present, said that despite the show being in Kannada, she was able to follow it, which she called, "a dream". Agreed Subrahmanyam, who added, "I have seen grand ballets in Canada, Russia and France but this show made us proud of India. It was a harmonious blend of old and new, and classical and modern."

Audience members too shared similar opinion, some even coming from outside Bengaluru just for the show. Dermatologist Dr Rashmi Shetty, who hails from Mumbai, was all praise for the "Disney-tisation" of the show, adding that the sequences involving Raavan and his 10 heads was one of her favourites.

The second day of the festival, which took place on February 15, had an interdisciplinary conclave, whereas the third day, slotted for February 22, will recreate Madanothsava, which is a more-than-1,000-year-old festival to welcome spring.



Pics: Saptarshi Mukherjee

> **I have seen grand ballets in Canada, Russia and France but this show made us proud of India. It was a harmonious blend of old and new, and classical and modern**
> —Dr Padma Subrahmanyam, Bharata Natyam dancer



TODAY'S
THE NEW INDIAN EXPRESS City
Bengaluru Express



DAY'S DIARY

Film premiere

Planet of the Apes, a 1968 American science fiction film directed by Franklin J Schaffner, premiered on this day in 1968

MAKEUP TECHNIQUES

The film was groundbreaking for its prosthetic makeup techniques by artist John Chambers and was well received by critics and audiences, launching a film franchise



NOMINATIONS

The film was nominated for Best Costume Design and Best Original Score for a Motion Picture. The score is known for its avant-garde compositional techniques



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SPRING IN STEP



Spring is always inspiring for artists to create something so we've organised the festival in an outdoor location, at Ramanjaneya Temple, Hanumanthanagar

—**Nirupama**, Kathak and Bharatanatyam dancer

Parva will recreate age-old spring festivities with poetry, dance, plays and games; will also have a Broadway-style show and conclave featuring Pt Birju Maharaj, Pravin Godkhindi, and others

Express Features

City-based Abhinava Dance Company completes 25 years of existence, and in order to commemorate the same, the couple behind the company, Nirupama and Rajendra, are organising Parva, a dance-festival. The three-day event will take place on February 14, 15 and 22, with a slew of different activities and productions planned for the same. The last day of the festival looks at recreating Madanothsava, which is a more-than-1,000-year-old festival to welcome spring, says Rajendra, founder and artistic director of the company. "Since Madana is the god of love, this is like the Indian way of celebrating Valentines Day," says Nirupama, with a smile, adding that since these are festivities to welcome spring, one can look forward to various mango dishes, a special dance on flowers and more. "Spring is always inspiring for artists to create something so we've organised it in an outdoor location, at Ramanjaneya Temple, Hanumanthanagar," adds Nirupama.

Set up in 1994, the idea behind the company was to add a new dimension to dance and bring it forward in an entertaining and accessible way as well. "And now, in our 25th year, it's the perfect time to pause, look back and see how far we have come," says Nirupama, a Kathak and Bharatanatyam dancer, choreographer and artistic director of the company.

Each day of the festival has been carefully planned to give audience members a new experience, which begins with the production Rama Katha Vismaya on February 14. Featuring 70 artistes on and off stage, the production will be showcased in the style of a Western broadway musical, complete with large props, costumes and symphony orchestra. "It will feature Kathak and special vocabulary from Natya Shastra, along with profound literature and spoken language. We wanted to introduce this large scale format in India so that productions get a similar status to cinema," explains Nirupama, who will also be making an appearance in the 90-minute production.

If the first day focuses on showcasing young talent, the agenda for the second is to bring together maestros from different art mediums and give people an idea of how they work in their particular field. This inter-disciplinary conclave, slotted for February 15, will feature eminent names such as Pandit Birju Maharaj, Pravin Godkhindi, Praveen D Rao, Saroj Khan, Rajiv Menon and more, where each will give the audience an idea about a different topic. For example, Menon will discuss the limitations, scope, influence and innovations in classical music in films, Khan will look at how traditional dance moves can be adapted for popular media and so on.

Many community activities are also being organised to involve participants as much as possible. "We will teach everyone simple moves so that they can join in and perform with us," says Rajendra, adding that people can also expect traditional gara[illegible] extempore dance performances and a "high-level scholarly game", one that is similar to antakshari, but which involves literature instead. "Our culture has always been rooted towards wellness but this is something we tend to forget in the fast-paced world we live in. Celebrations like these can help people be healthy and joyful," says Nirupama.



Nirupama and Rajendra

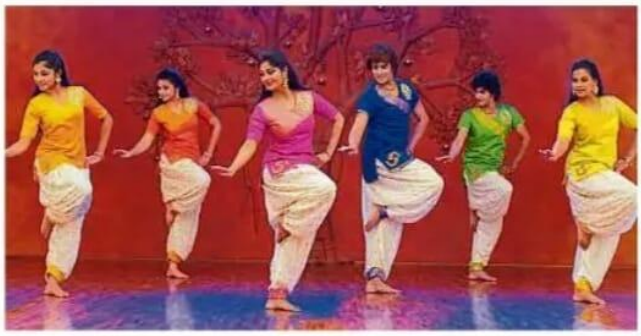
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KATHAK STARS





COLOURFUL PERFORMANCES Nirupama and Rajendra with their troupe.

The dancing duo

They are different in every way except in their shared passion for the dance form, Nirupama & Rajendra tell RASHMI VASUDEVA

Popular kathak-duo Nirupama and Rajendra's latest production is titled *Abhisaar*. It wouldn't be an exaggeration to say that the couple themselves are on a lifelong *abhisaar*.

"*Abhisaar* means to be in pursuit," says Rajendra while Nirupama nods vigorously. "It could be a student going to a new city to study, an entrepreneur beginning a business venture; it could even be birds beginning their migration, or it could be a woman's search for love," she says.

It could also be two dancers, passionate about their art, coming together in their search for perfection, like Niru and Raju, as they are fondly known, did nearly 30 years ago.

Pushing boundaries

Even three decades later, their love for each other is as palpable as their commitment to their art. "We are very different people, but right from the start, our vision was the same — it was to take our art beyond its pre-conceived boundaries. We were young and hungry — eager to eat up new concepts, bring in different sounds and tinker with a range of choreography," says Nirupama. She believes her innate spontaneity and "lust for celebration" gelled well with Rajendra's solid technical knowledge of music and dance as well as his immersion in traditional arts because of his family influences.

"It is not as if we didn't have our differences," muses Rajendra. But he is quick to add that it was those differences that they converted into strengths. "It was never about who is right but what is right for our work. This *mantra* has held us together," says Niru.

Indeed. So much so that today, Niru-Raju's organisation Abhinava Dance Company is admired for its cohesion, arguably the biggest reason for the slickness of their presentations, be it the Broadwayesque *Ram-katha Vismaya*, the mercurial *Kathakitatom* or the spectacularly colourful *Rang*, as its very name suggests.

Often, their productions are never kathak in its purest form. Has this got them flak from the classicists? "As a couple we decided very early on to practice the kind of art which does not become an obligation for the audience. We didn't want people to turn up because it is some relative's *rangapravesha*; we wanted them to come only for art's sake. And this meant tweaking the form, brainstorming, falling and getting up but being determined to take it further," says Nirupama.

Rajendra recalls an incident where, in a festival of male dancers, he had performed *Param-Purush* an out-of-the-box look at masculinity and femininity. Some critics had sniggered about whether the hero was the dancer or the stage lighting! "Such responses only inspire us further. We strongly believe there is space for traditionalists, post-modernists, as well as those who want to follow a middle path. One needs courage as well as talent to go beyond set boundaries and yet appeal to the audience," he feels.

As part of this quest to 'present *paramparas* with a new intelligence' as Nirupama puts it, they approached their mentor and *guru* Dr Shatavadhani Ganesh, a polyglot-scholar, when it was time to brainstorm for a new production. "That was when he laid out the possibilities of *abhisaar* for us," explains Nirupama. "There are many wonderful aspects of our mythologies and epics apart from the much-performed bits of the *Ramayana* and the *Mahabharata*. We literally were trying to sniff out some of these unknown gems," she says.

Eventually, they zoomed in on the journey of an *abhisarika* who goes in search of her beloved in the middle of the night. "Imagine... this story has humour, dread, anticipation, a sense of adventure all wrapped up in the sentiment of love. The *abhisarika*, after a journey fraught with surprises, catches sight of her beloved and freezes. We stopped the performance at that point and asked the audience to come up with their versions of what happens next," narrates Nirupama.

Search continues

What happened next was that the surprised audience did come up with many interpretations; and Nirupama (who played *abhisarika*) chose a few and performed them on the spot. "The audience were thoroughly enlivened — and this is what we mean when we say our classical arts need to be looked at with a new eye," she adds.

The dancing couple's appetite for an innovative vision has resulted in several successful experiments, the most recent being *Madanotsava*, a day-long celebration of spring that garnered much appreciation from all over. "It was a carnival of music, traditional games, food, group activities... we never had so much fun before," recalls Rajendra. What Rajendra does not say but implies is that for the couple, dancing has always been about *ananda*, one of those Sanskrit words heavy with meaning but quite untranslatable. And it is in this pursuit of *ananda* (fun, if you insist) that they have found success as well as togetherness.

Festival to celebrate spring this Sunday

DHNS, MAR 03 2023, 00:45 IST | UPDATED: MAR 03 2023, 01:04 IST



The third edition of community spring festival 'Madanotsava' will be held at Ramanjaneya Gudda Temple in Hanumanthanagar on Sunday.

Classical dancer-couple Nirupama and Rajendra of the Abhinava Dance Company has been organising the festival to celebrate the arrival of spring, as per tradition. Scholar and poet R Ganesh helped them to revive the seasonal practice.

The day-long festival will feature a Bharatanatyam recital by Shankar Kandasamy, a musical ession by Pravin Godkhindi and Krishna Band, a classical performance by Carnatic vocal and olin duo Ranjani and Gayatri, among others. Hosts Nirupama and Rajendra will also put up a ance showcase.

raditional activities such as sahakaara bhanjikothsava where people dance around a mango tree nd pluck mangoes, and charchari nrithya where people clap, sing and dance in a circle or in airs are planned. Also on the roster are traditional games like *huli-kuri aata, aluguli mane, howka-baara and chathuranga.*

he venue will also have stalls of handloom and handicraft products, and books and food.

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CITYLINE

Adding new dimensions to creativity

(Contd from page 1)
in our traditions. We are not diluting the form, though the treatment is modern. We are adding new dimensions to the possibilities of creativity. Keeping the four modes of communication -- *Aangika, Vaachika, Ahariya* and the most important *Satvikam* - in our Natya Shastra very much intact," adds T D Rajendra.

The Bangalore-based couple- proud recipients of various prestigious dance titles- have tinged the North Indian classical dance form with a subtle *shastric* flavour. Their distinctive repertoire of performances is testimony to the fact that when art is only about aesthetics and not boundaries, it opens up new possibilities and expands creative limits. "Our presentations have many stories, Kalidas' work, Valmiki's Ramayana, Draupadi, Mahabharata and more woven into the production. When Kathak is presented as a story, the audience can feel all your emotions and has a higher recall value," asserts Nirupama Rajendra, whose dance academy, Abhinaya Dance Company, is home to 600 students!

For the past several years, Nirupama and Rajendra have emerged as a successful Kathak duo, performing at crème da la crème festivals in India and abroad. But Kathak was not the first choice. Nirupama Rajendra is an accomplished Bharatanatyam soloist, while Rajendra, also a Bharatanatyam artist, belongs to a 63-member joint family who are *harikatha* practitioners. But they were fascinated by the story-telling facet of Kathak, the *ghungroos*, and *sitar* and wanted to tell stories through movements!

Their training happened at many levels, with Guru Maya Rao's introduction to Kathak, then learning the contemporary Kathak under trailblazer Kumidini Lakhia, with valuable inputs gleaned from Pandit Arjun Mishra of the Lucknow Gharana, and the finer nuances of Lahori Kathak under Pakistani Kathak icon Nahid Siddiqui, among many others.

Working with a partner for 33 years, who is also a dancer, comes with challenges. "We are always in sync in our thoughts. But we have our strengths as well. For example, Rajendra is extraordinary with lighting and sound, and I am versatile in several dance forms, so I handle the choreography. We have one common passion and love for art, so things like who is right never emerges. For us, it is always 'what is right'. We complement each other. If I'm the melody, he will be the rhythm; we are married to our art," they laughingly add.

Talking about the road ahead, Nirupama says, "Any good work will always be remembered. All the Insta dances and trend of reels are but for that moment. It is forgotten faster than the time it took to play. No one can be immune to the *tapas* and *sadhana* of a true artist. Those who watch a live performance will never forget it. Though the maestros are few, but their effect will be everlasting," Nirupama Rajendra says on the parting note.

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CityLi
EXCLUSIVE FOR THE READERS I
SUNDAY, January 29, 2023

Adding new dimensions to creativity


Satish Raut

Gurus Nirupama Rajendra and T D Rajendra in a graceful performance during 'Kaladarshan' at Bhavan's BP Auditorium, on Saturday.

■ By Farina Salim Quraishi

SUNDAY SPECIAL

ARTISTS don't always need words to express themselves. For the artists, who set the stage on fire with their fine nuances, dance is the language of the soul and they dance to express. Gurus Nirupama Rajendra and T D Rajendra are that and so much more. The celebrated soloists create sheer magic with their deft footwork when they get on the stage together. Much like two wholes coming together to make a stronger whole, there is style, substance, synchrony, symmetry, and an inexplicable charm to their stunning performances. Celebrated for their expressions, movements, energy and presentation, the dynamic dancing couple proves that a flick of a wrist or a blink of an eye can speak a thousand words.

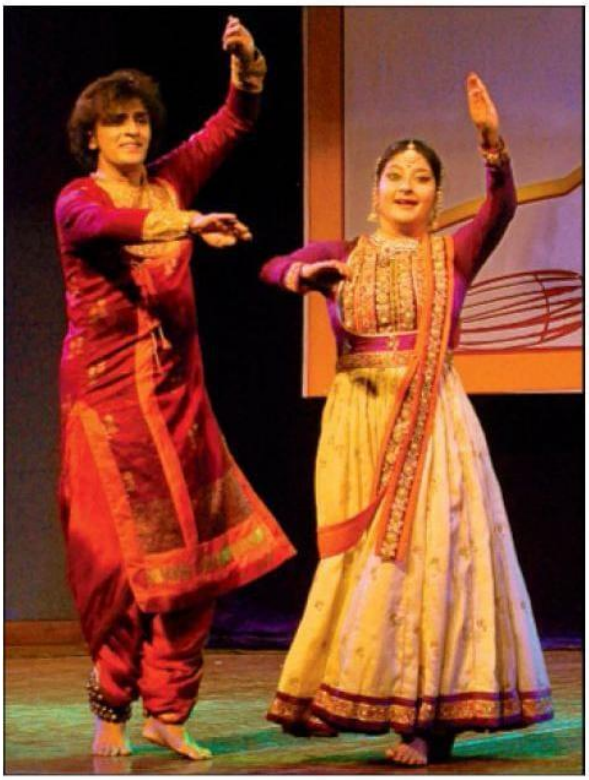
The doyens of the Indian classical and their dance company - Abhinaya Dance Company - have become the toast of the Indian Classical scene in India and abroad. Deeply ingrained in tradition, the duo's productions are a fusion of ethnic and contemporary dance with musical influences from genres like Jazz, Spanish, Afro, and World Music. Great music, designer costumes, razzmatazz sound, and lighting effects have come to define their stunning productions.

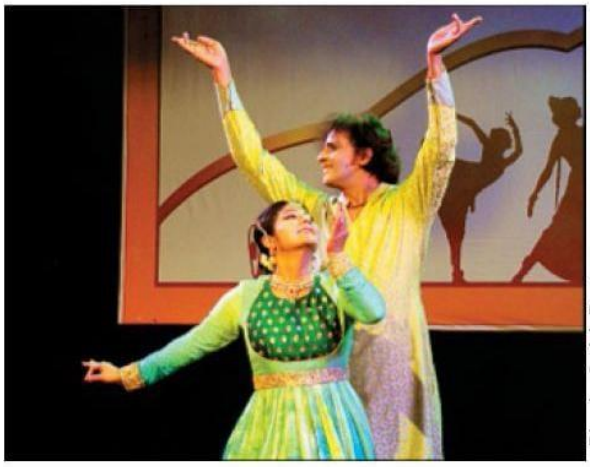
Speaking as one voice and often completing each other's sentences, the graceful and articulate couple redefine the definition of 'two bodies and one soul' with their seamless unity. Talking about their broadway style presentations, Nirupama Rajendra says, "An artist cannot be an egoist. He has to take a few steps to connect to his audience so they can step forward. Classical dancers have to embrace the world. Assuming that an artist will only perform for a niche audience is being naive. In today's milieu, we have to present Kathak in a form that everyone can enjoy. "We have seen broadway musicals, Las Vegas shows and more and realised that we can easily present Kathak as a musical production, one which is rooted in tradition. Kathak, after all, is *katha vachan*. So we have brought the story-telling element back to Kathak. Our speciality is crafting new choreographies rooted

(Contd on page 2)

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Kaladarshan leaves audience spellbound





Pics by Satish Raut

■ Staff Reporter

IF THERE'S a staircase to heaven, a stepping stone, or a rope way to it, perhaps it's art. There's magic to an artists ability to evoke feelings that extend beyond simple emotions. These artists, Kathak performers gracefully gliding, and twirling in their elaborate dresses against the backdrop of lights was a sequence picked from an art lovers mind. Their feet slapping against the wooden floor, the sonorous jingling of the Ghungroo, and the twirling of the fabric with every turn and action was perfection.

Words cannot explain the experience of watching Nirupama Rajendra and T D Rajendra, Artistic Directors, Abhinava Dance Company, Bangalore performing at Bhavan's Bhagwandas Purohit Auditorium, Civil lines, on Saturday. Organised by Kalasrjan Academy of Classical Music, Dance and Fine Arts operated by Bhartiya Vidya Bhavan Nagpur Kendra is a dedicated platform to conserve, promote and propagate Indian Classical art.

The performance opens on an auspicious note of devotion to Vittala on various Abhangas. Performing a sequence based on *Dohas* from Ramcharitra Manasa by Tulasidas can be translated as the beauty of divine beings dancing in bliss. Presenting the divine love of Lord Rama and Princess Sita through the gentle and graceful movements of the wrists, the brow, and the feet transported the audience to a divine world, a divine world which one wants to experience more of.

The stern yet gentle godlike stature of Lord Rama and the poised dainty Sita twirling in a love orbit, locked in a hopeless and selfless inertia -- destined to be eachothers was the moment the audience fell in love with the artists ability to tell stories vividly and creatively. It is in these performances that one believes art to be the bane of human existence. Performing many such sequences representing the various colours of life touched everybody's hearts in ways they cannot explain.

Pravin D Rao, Pravin Godkhandi, Shatavadhani Dr R Ganesh, Santosh N, and Ajay V of the Abhinava Dance Company worked hard for the success of the event along with the stars of the show -- Nirupama Rajendra and T D Rajendra. Padmini Jog, Executive Committee Member, Bhartiya Vidya Bhavan, Nagpur Kendra presided over the programme. Rajendra Purohit, Chairman; Annapoorni Shastri, Director; Srimathy S Madkholkar, Principal were prominently present at the event.

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culture

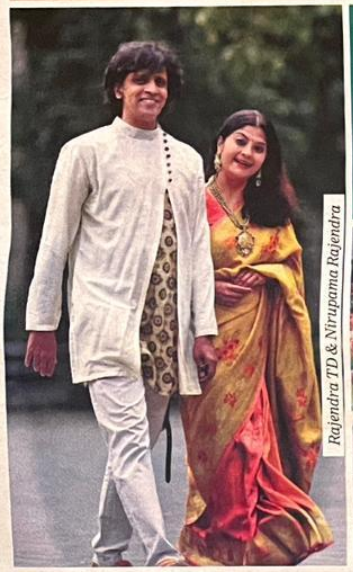
music/dance/drama



curtain raiser

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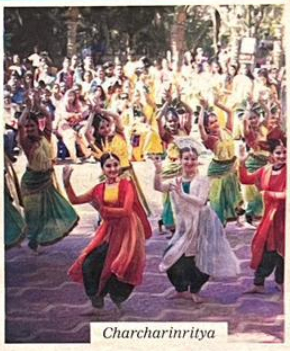
MADANOTHSAVA IS BACK AFTER A TWO YEAR HIATUS



Rajendra TD & Nirupama Rajendra



Dance performance at the festival



Charcharinritya

MADANOTHSAVA OR VASANTHOSAVA is the brainchild of dance exponents Nirupama Rajendra and Rajendra TD. First held in 2018, the third edition of this upcoming festival features an array of performances and activities that the viewers can also be part of. These include the traditional *sahakara bhanjikotsava*, *charcharinritya*, various musical and dance performances, traditional board games and multiple stalls that have handlooms, handicrafts, books and food. Some of the performances to look forward to include a Hindustani classical performance by Venkatesh Kumar, bharatanrittam by Abhinava Dance Company and a carnatic classical perform-ance by Ranjani & Gayatri. We talk to Nirupama, who co-started *Madanothsava* in the city and is also the co-founder of Abhinava Dance Company.

"*Madanothsava* festival, which involves all types of arts, so, we did not restrict ourselves to one particular style. We are open to all styles of dance. We have *kuchipudi*, *bharatanatyam*, *odissi* and *kathak*. We follow the same for music as well," Nirupama begins.

The past editions of the festival had multiple features like sand art, shadow plays and glow art. Nirupama believes that the audience should also take part in these activities. "In earlier times, there used to be *aasthanakavis* and there were various challenges given by the king. So, we have kept *chaturavadhana* (an impromptu poetic feat) and *avadhanam*. Through such events, the audience will also be able to participate," she adds.

The festival also features two special dance called *charcharinritya* and *sahakaarabhanjikothsava*, which directly involve the participation of the audience. In the performance known as *sahakaarabhanjikothsava*, participants dance around a mango tree while simultaneously picking mangoes from the tree. The Vijayanagara Empire's poets and writers Kalidasa and Vemabhupala both mention the *charcharinritya*. "The audience won't just be watching the dancers perform but will come and dance along with us. There won't be a separation between a professional performer and the audience," adds the dancer.

Talking about the future projects, the dancer reveals, "We have musicals, which are like the Disney-style musicals, but on the *Ramayana* and the *Mahabharata*. We are looking to stage them in April-May. We also have a possible tour to the US in September on the occasion of 50 years of the Kannada Association there."

Entry free. March 5, 7.30 am.
At Ramanjaneya Gudda, Hanumanthanagar

— Alwin Benjamin Soji
alwin@newindianexpress.com @al_ben_so

CITY PLAYS HOST TO A CONFLUENCE OF DANCE AND MUSIC

SNAPSHOTS FROM A RECENTLY-HELD MUSIC AND DANCE EXTRAVAGANZA IN THE CITY THAT SAW A HOST OF ARTISTES COMING TOGETHER TO RAISE FUNDS FOR THE REHABILITATION OF KODAGU AND KERALA FLOOD VICTIMS. CALLED *DHAARA*, THIS CREATIVE COLLABORATION WITNESSED PERFORMANCES BY NIRUPAMA, RAJENDRA, KUMARESH, JAYANTHI, PRAVEEN AND PRAMATH

Pics: Rakesh Ravindran



REVIEW / REPORT

Rasārādhanam - An exemplary tribute to the Rasas and to the compositions of Śatāvadhānī Dr. R Ganesh

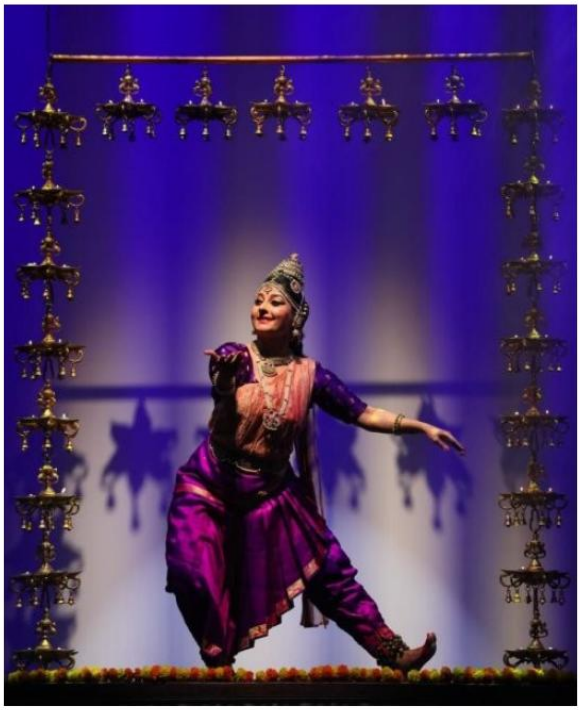
- Arjun Bharadwaj
e-mail: arjunbharadwaj@gmail.com

September 28, 2026

20 September 2026 offered a special audio-visual treat to the rasikas of Bengaluru. Nirupama Rajendra presented Bharatanrityam to compositions by Śatāvadhānī Dr R. Ganesh. The event was hosted by the team of Rasārādhana as a tribute to Dr Ganesh on his being conferred the Padma Bhushan. The honour has indeed found a most deserving recipient and serves as a fitting recognition of Ganesh's enduring contributions to diverse domains of classical poetry, the arts, and the *śāstras*. Nirupama Rajendra's offering was especially meaningful, for she owes much of her understanding of the philosophy underlying the Nāṭyaśāstra, as well as her insights into classical literature, to Ganesh.

The performance was aptly titled a Bharatanrityam offering, for Nirupama Rajendra primarily employed the movement vocabulary of the immortal treatise Nāṭyaśāstra, as reconstructed by Dr. Padma Subrahmanyam. Nirupama, who is known for her excellence in two styles - Bharatanatyam and Kathak, learnt the vocabulary from Late Sundari Santhanam, one of the prime disciples of Dr. Padma Subrahmanyam. In the words of Nirupama, this marga vocabulary has immensely enriched both her desi styles and has increased the possibilities for creative expression multiple-fold. T. D. Rajendra and Nirupama have extensively used these movements and their adaptations in all their

six continents. Nirupama's presentation also included a unique vocabulary she conceived, bridging the *marga* with the *desi*. These 108 movements, called the *Desi-Marga-Aḍavus*, were developed by her during the lockdown of Covid-19, keeping in mind the psychosomatic correlations and the creative possibilities of movements. The movements, which took their birth under the guidance of Dr. Ganesh and were named by him, not only work as pedagogical tools, but also as important media for communication. While the upper body is designed to follow the *nṛtta hastas* of the Nāṭyaśāstra, the lower body performs the *aḍavus*, thereby making it a blend of the *marga* and the *desi*. This contribution alone is sufficient to make Nirupama immortal in the echelons of time.



Nirupama (Anjali)

The evening began with a beautiful *anjali* dedicated to Bhagavan Srikrishna. The lines go, *Desi Gokula dharaṇi tale Mrrga Murāriravatarati*: The Divine, all-pervading Murāri takes birth upon the soil of Gokula, just like the pan-Indian *marga* finds its regional application in the *desi*. Nirupama succinctly brought to life the environs of Gokula through her impeccable abhinaya, by employing the *karaṇas* and the aforementioned *Desi-Marga-Aḍavus*. She displayed the leelas of Srikrishna. The short piece, set to raga Kalyaṇi and involving numerous *gati bhedas* provided an auspicious beginning to the program. The music was composed by Rajkumar Bharati.

The second choreography is a masterpiece by any standard. Titled *Atma saundarya*, the composition traces Devi Parvati's journey from a maiden to becoming Bhagavan Śiva's inseparable

anything around him. Parvati tries to win him over by her physical charms and enticing costume. Manmatha, who symbolises Parvati's love, appears there, casting a spell of romantic companionship all around him. Nirupama suggestively indicated that Parvati's very desire for Śiva manifested as *Vasanta* and *Malaya maruta*, which in turn act as *uddīpana vibhāvas* for her love. She creatively depicted Manmatha choosing his bow by picking up a sugarcane, biting it, relishing its taste, and deciding that it would serve to amplify the sweetness of his endeavour. Bees form his bowstring, and five flowers constitute his arrows. Just as he spots Śiva in *tapas* and shoots an arrow at him to make him fall in love, he is reduced to ashes by the fire that emerged from the rageful third eye of the lord. Parvati, who witnesses this, is heartbroken and decides that all her external beauty is of no use; the *jaganmata* offers all her aspects of beauty to nature. Nirupama's enactment of this sequence is inimitable. The deer, which had rather dull eyes until then, become bright and bubbling due to the gift of the goddess's eye. The lotuses smile by blossoming wide, having received the beauty of Parvati's lips. Similarly, the creepers develop dainty and curvy bodies, and snakes wrap around each other, being blessed with the charm of devi's body and tresses. Having thus embodied her physical beauty in nature, Parvati performs *tapas* in all six seasons. Nirupama's depiction of the seasons was so appealing and accurate that the audience could almost feel the scorching heat of the sun and the chilling winds of winter. The creative lighting and accompanying music enhanced the effect to provide a multi-dimensional treat to the connoisseur.

Parvati performs *tapas* amidst four fires in the cardinal directions, with the Sun being the fifth fire. She is unflinching in the rainy season, the autumn, the winters and the harvest season. Nirupama succinctly portrayed the overflowing rivers of the rainy season by doing a quick sanchari that indicated the river Ganga, which was brought down to the earth by Sage Bhagiratha. She suggested the *Hemanta ṛtu* by depicting the harvest of crops, without ever compromising on the tala or the movements of her feet. As though to test her commitment, Śiva appears in the disguise of a *brahmachari*. The lord changing his guise was also enacted as a humorous sequence by the artiste. The *brahmachari* taunts Parvati by saying that she is going behind a person whose parentage is unknown and who lives in the crematorium, constantly asking, *kīdṛśo mahātmā*? For each one of the questions, Parvati provides a philosophical answer, thereby emphasising the realisation of Śiva *tattva* within herself. Impressed, Śiva surrenders to her and wishes to marry her. While Parvati is overcome by immense joy and is bashful, she asks him to put forth the proposal to her father.



Nirupama (Atma saundarya)

Thus, the composition amply emphasises the importance of the spiritual union of a couple, rather than an attraction founded merely on the physical. It is *Atma saundarya* that brings the primordial couple together, and not *deha saundarya*. Inspired by Kalidasa's immortal epic Kumarasambhavam, the composition traces Parvati's progression from *aharya* and *aṅgika*, through *vachika*, culminating in her realisation of *sattvika śiva* within herself. The composition was set in Ragamalika and Talamalika, providing ample scope for the musicians to bring forth the best of their creative abilities. Praveen D Rao composed the music, skilfully weaving in dramatic elements that heightened both the narrative and its underlying emotions. Nirupama's deep understanding of classical literature lent further depth and nuance to the interpretations she presented.

The next composition was structured to bring out the essential non-difference between Hari and Hara. Bhagavan Śiva and Śriman Narayaṇa are manifestations of the same underlying principle, and the composition portrayed Śiva and Vishnu as mutual admirers. Śiva wishes to hear the melodious strains of the flute played by Vishnu in his avatara as Srikrishna, while the latter wishes to hear Śiva's rhythmic playing of the ḍamaru. The flute represents melody - śruti - while the

ḍamaru represents rhythm - laya; together, they constitute music. Thus, both divinities are shown to be indispensable to the art of music. Vishnu demonstrates the manner in which he danced upon the slippery hoods of the Kaliya serpent, while Śiva displays his *Ananda taṇḍava* in the *kanaka sabha*. Nirupama's creativity and meticulous attention to detail in these segments served as a masterclass for students of both dance and literature. She depicted the manner in which Srikrishna performed the *mardana* of Kaliya, rather than his *saṃhara*, and emphasised how he never lost his balance during the dance. She even assumed the posture immortalised in Chola bronzes depicting Kṛishna's final stance upon the hoods of Kaliya, with the serpent's tail drawn upwards. Nirupama's mastery over *sthiti* and *gati* in dance was particularly evident in these passages. The *sanatanic* divinities are celebrated not merely for their *saukumarya* as artists; they also manifest *uddhata* qualities in their *avataras* and *leelas*. The composition accordingly proceeded to the portrayal of Rama vanquishing Ravaṇa. After depicting the ferocity of the battle, traversing *vira* and *raudra* rasas, Nirupama did not fail to bring out Rama's *karuṇya* upon the death of Ravaṇa. Rama proceeds to ensure the rakshasa's cremation, bringing to mind the celebrated words of the Ramayaṇa - *maraṇāntāni vairāṇi*.

Nirupama then depicted Śiva's vanquishing of the *tripurāsuras*, the *rakṣhasas* who had assumed the form of three cities. The *trimurtis*, together with the Earth, the Sun, the Moon, Mount Meru, the Vedas, and the infinite serpent Ananta, come together in the destruction of the *asuras*. Having thus portrayed the *avataras* and *leelas* of the Divine, Nirupama brought the composition to a close with a charming familial touch. Hari and Hara, accompanied by their respective spouses, mount their vehicles and journey forth to meet and greet one another. The conclusion thus also brought to the fore the family values embodied by the divinities - their *gṛhastha dharma*.

The next presentation was an aesthetic amalgamation of two compositions by Ganesh, skilfully woven together by Nirupama into a coherent and touching narrative. While the first three presentations were rooted in themes centred on the Divinities, this fourth presentation was rich in *lokadharmi*, exploring an entirely human theme without recourse to supernatural elements. The compositions, titled *Dautya dīkṣite* and *Rasika sahāye*, are novel conceptions of Ganesh, conceived within the classical framework of *nayika abhinaya*.

In the first of the two, a heroine, yearning for the company of her beloved who is away on a journey, wonders about the ideal medium through which she might send him her message of love. She considers several possibilities, only to discover that none would quite serve her purpose. If she were to entrust her message to the clouds, they might melt away, washing away her colourful dreams with them; if she were to request the wind to carry it, the wind might scatter the

message in all directions, diluting its intensity. A parrot might not preserve her confidence, while a peacock, beautiful though it is to behold, possesses a harsh voice. After contemplating these possibilities, the nayika finally decides to send her own mind as the messenger - but alas! The mind reaches her beloved and never returns. The poet's ingenuity and the dancer's impeccable ability to communicate even the subtlest of ideas reigned supreme in the presentation of this composition. The narrative then proceeds with the same nayika being teased by her sakhi, who suggests that her beloved might not remain faithful to her. The nayika, however, as a *svadhinapatika*, displays an unwavering and proud confidence in her husband, declaring that she could never become a *khaṇḍita* or a *kalahantarita*. Nirupama, who peppered the enactment of this second composition with abundant *hasya*, deftly brought out both the charm and the profundity of true couplehood.

The compositions were set to music by Rajkumar Bharati, employing the ragas Ratipatipriya, Vasanta, Rasikapriya, Durga, Ritigowla, and Hemavati.

The evening concluded with a tillana in the raga Sumanoranjini, set to music by Dr. Nagavalli Nagaraj. Nirupama started the presentation of the composition from the lyrics, which went *Tapanavaṃśa soma! Sunāma!* Addressing Sri Rama as the cool moon of the lineage which started from the blazing sun, the lyrics trace the personality of the Divine. Nirupama provided a visual commentary by enacting various episodes from his life at different spots on the stage. Then, for the pallavi and the anupallavi, she donned the roles of Hanuman and Lakshmaṇa, the best devotees of Sri Rama. Finally, to the lyrics of the charaṇa, Nirupama transformed herself into Sita, who is telling the story of Rama to Lava and Kusha. The sequence ends with Sita going back into her Mother Earth, having completed her duty in her avatara. Sri Rama, too, although distraught due to the separation from his beloved, is *nikama*, i.e., desires nothing for himself. He thus gathers himself together and continues to rule the world.

The recital thus ended on a serene and *dharmic* note. The recital, which started with Kṛishṇa, traversed through Śiva and concluded in the portrayal of Raja Rāma. It was truly a celebration of all rasas - *Rasārādhanam*. Speaking on the occasion, Dr. R Ganesh lauded Nirupama's ability to translate every idea into action, with no transmission losses. He observed her impeccable character-switching and deep *sattva* in every role. The celebrated musician, M. S. Sheela, the chief guest of the evening, called Nirupama *Abhinaya sharade*, a title she truly deserves.

The music ensemble included Raghuram on the vocals, Mahesh Swamy on the flute, Mattur Srinidhi on violin, Prashanth Rudrapattna on the veena, D.V.Prasanna Kumar on nattuvangam and Khanjira, and Vidyashankar on the mridangam. The ensemble, which consisted of many veterans, provided the best collaborative support to the dancer. The lighting was managed by Ajay Viajendra, who thoughtfully cast the colours to enhance abhinaya. Santosh, the wardrobe manager, did a fabulous job in decking the artiste as well.

The event was attended by many stalwarts from the fields of literature, dance, music, and painting and won the hearts of the lay and the learned alike.



Arjun Bharadwaj is a Sanskrit scholar with deep interest in literature, philosophy, and aesthetics. As a poet, he has penned numerous compositions for dance and theatre productions. Well-versed in Sanskrit, Kannada, English, Greek, and German languages, he has authored and translated over fifteen works, which have gained renown around the world.

HUBBALLI • SUNDAY • DECEMBER 01, 2024 • ₹12.00 • PAGES 26 • CITY EDITION

CT SCHEDULE: PCB, BCCI STILL TRYING TO FIND TANGIBLE SOLUTION

ICC is yet to announce any formal schedule for Champions Trophy. Though hybrid model is likely, yet ICC, BCCI & PCB are thrashing out finer points

PCB MAY NOT PLAY ICC EVENTS IN INDIA

After two days of discussions, Pakistan Cricket Board chief M told a few reporters in Dubai that they would take a decision in interest of cricket. However, he also said that whatever decision the ICC takes now will have a bearing on the future ICC tournaments hosted by India till 2031. If India doesn't travel, Pakistan too won't come to India

CHENNAI ▪ MADURAI ▪ VIJAYAWADA ▪ BENGALURU ▪ KOCHI ▪ HYDERABAD ▪ VISAKHAPATNAM ▪ COIMBATORE ▪ KOZHIKODE ▪ THIRUVANANTHAPURAM ▪ BELAGAVI ▪ BHUBANESWAR ▪ SHIVAMOGGA ▪ MANGALURU ▪ TIRUPATI ▪ TIRUCHY ▪ T



(From left) Devi Awardees, Vimor Co-founder Pavithra Muddaya; Professor and Dean (Research), National Centre for Biological Science, Dr Vatsala Thirumalai; classical dancer Nirupama Rajendra; TNIE CEO Laxmi Menon; Mitti Cafe Founder and CEO Alina Alam; two-time Olympian Anju Bobby George; TNIE Chairman Manoj Kumar Sonthalia; former Infosys CEO SD Shibulal; TNIE Editorial Director Prabhu Chawla; NIMHANS Director Dr Pratima Murthy; TNIE Editor Santwana Bhattacharya; Science Gallery Bengaluru Founding Director Jahnavi Phalkey; Director of Events Xpress, Neha Sonthalia Periwal; Founder and Managing Trustee of Neev Schools, Kavitha Gupta Sabharwal; restaurateur Sonali Sattar; author Samhita Arni; and Founder and Managing Trustee of Sanket Trust, Arundhati Nag, pose with their awards at the 29th edition of the Devi Awards in Bengaluru on Saturday. Meanwhile, Kalyani collected the award on behalf of Portea Medical Co-founder and Chairperson Meena Ganesh | VINOD KUMAR T

Devi Awards celebrates woman power, pays tribute to 12 trailblazers

EXPRESS NEWS SERVICE
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TWELVE trailblazing women -- from a serial entrepreneur to a handloom revivalist to an Olympian to an inclusive activist -- who have made an impact

Meena Ganesh; author Samhita Arni; founder of Mitti Cafe Alina Alam; educationist Kavita Gupta Sabharwal; handloom revivalist Pavithra Muddaya; founding director of Science Gallery Bengaluru Jahnavi Phalkey; clas-

New Indian Express Group. "I am particularly happy to share this stage with The New Indian Express Group, an organisation that has consistently amplified the voices of trailblazing women across India," he remarked.

exemplary ability to lead in ways that transform not only enterprises but entire economies and societies..."

He pointed out that studies have ascertained the truth that companies with greater gender diversity outperform their peers

12 Devis from different fields were felicitated at a glitzy event in Bengaluru that celebrated womanhood in its many avatars

WHERE DYNAMISM & INNOVATION TOOK THE ST


Anju Bobby George, two-time Olympian


Kavita Gupta Sabharwal, Founder & Managing Trustee, Neev Schools


Nirupama Rajendra, Classical dancer


Pavithra Muddaya, Co-founder, Vimor


Dr Pratima Murthy, Director, NIMHANS


Arundhati Nag, Founder & Managing Trustee, Sanket Trust


Jahnavi Phalkey, Founding director, Science Gallery Bengaluru


Dr Vatsala Thirumalai, Prof & Dean, National Centre for Biological Sciences



DEVIS EXPLORE THE POWER OF THEIR SUPERPOWERS

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"IF I have a superpower, I would ask the rich to set up theatres like Rangashankara in the small towns of India," said Arundhati Nag, theatre exponent and founder of Rangashankara — Bengaluru's cherished theatre space which recently completed its 20th anniversary.

She was in conversation with Kaveree Bamzai, noted author and journalist, at the Roundtable with the Devis – 'Leading Change: What's the Superpower?' held as part of the 29th edition of the Devi Awards instituted by The New Indian Express, on Saturday.

Stating that theatres need not always have to originate from Tier-1 cities like New Delhi, Mumbai and Bengaluru, Arundhati said it's time theatres are introduced in 'B' and 'C' category cities.

Further, she said when theatres like Rangashankara are set up in small towns, it will make a huge difference, and added that it was her dream.

Educationist, founder and managing trustee of Neev Schools Kavita Gupta Sabharwal, who is batting for education for children said, "We deal with around 15,000 children at our school, while also working with government and orphanage schools. Many children are deprived of a proper education."

Earlier, at the roundtable, Kavita said while India is changing, education has failed to keep up. "If there is a new tryst with the destiny India has to make, it has to be education. We have to change the definition of what 'excellence in education' means, "she said, adding that education must redefine its vision.

Further into the roundtable, author Samhita Arni said if she had a superpower, she would create an economy and make arts productive and generate more revenue. "There are many young fiction writers who do not get ample opportunities like the ones we have. I wish to make arts more productive, by creating infrastructure for publishing, marketing, and changing the revenue model, thus providing better income to arts professionals," Samhita said.

Jahnavi Phalkey, a science and technology historian, batted for the setting up of public libraries and parks and museum-like galleries, which are located at a 15-minute distance from anywhere. Jahnavi said that because of the fear of failure, the ability to think differently is severely compromised. "Failures are everywhere, but nowhere to be seen. Even when historians write about various aspects of the history of science, failures are seldom narrated," she added, and reminded that it takes multiple rockets, before the actual rocket is launched. "It is important to bring such things to the public," she said. The historian stressed on the need to build a connection with science to become informed and capable citizens.

'Glass ceiling will shatter when we shift mindsets'

CONTINUED FROM PAGE 1

"THIS particular quality – rare and essential – is shared by each of the women we are recognising here today. It is a quality rooted in knowing that success is not solitary, it is not personal, it cannot be measured by a single metric, and it does not exist in isolation," he elaborated. "Women in leadership approach their own success as the success of those around them – their families, communities, and countries. When women succeed, they make sure to take the rest of us with them. We cannot acknowledge the outstanding achievements of the women here today without recognising that they have done so despite a largely unequal playing field. The barriers that continue to curb opportunities and growth of women need to be broken. And much work remains to be done.

"While partly accomplished by corporate policies, legislation and external factors, the glass ceiling will most thoroughly and permanently shatter when we begin to shift mindsets. A mindset that compels society to educate, encourage and enable women to lead boldly and unapologetically," he said. He hoped that the women honoured with Devi Awards pull others up along with them, building a stronger, more resilient India. When women thrive, societies flourish, he added.

"As a strong believer in women empowerment, I heartily congratulate the 12 achievers and wish them the best to continue their relentless work, which will inspire other women," remarked Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah in his message.

The event also featured an engaging roundtable with Devis titled 'Leading Change: What's the Superpower?' Arundhati Nag, Kavita Gupta Sabharwal, Samhita Arni and Jahnavi Phalkey were part of the engaging conversation on varied issues.

TNIE CMD Manoj Kumar Sonthalia, Editorial Director of The New Indian Express Prabhu Chawla, Group CEO Lakshmi Menon and Editor Santwana Bhattacharya were present. Leader of Opposition in the Assembly R Ashoka, BJP MP Lehar Singh Siroya, Bengaluru South MP Tejasvi Surya and City Police Commissioner B Dayananda were among the audience.

Noted author Kaveree Bamzai moderated the session, including the candid interaction with the awardees.


Alina Alam, Founder and CEO, Mitti Cafe


Sonali Sattar, Restaurateur

A dazzling evening to remember for Devis and their families

EXPRESS NEWS SERVICE
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IT WAS AN EVENING to cherish for the Devi award winners, their friends and families who came down to watch their loved ones being honoured with the coveted award instituted by The New Indian Express on Saturday.

There were tears, cheers, applause, photo and video shoots of the big moment, as the winners accepted their awards and spoke a few words before the jam-packed audience around.

It turned out to be an inspirational evening for most of the men and women in the crowd when the achievements of each 'Devi' and her hardship on their route to success, were narrated and showcased on a giant screen.

There were many emotional faces around when inclusive activist Alina Alam, founder and CEO of Mitti Cafe, came on stage with her toddler, husband and a group of persons with disabilities who have a successful career. She conveyed her message of inclusiveness rather well, and also shared her moment of pride.


Bangalore South MP Tejasvi Surya with an employee of Mitti Cafe, at the Devi Awards ceremony | NAGARAJA GADEKAL

Many were lost in wonder when classical dancer Nirupama Rajendra, an awardee was asked to perform a small dance to depict the spirit of 'Devi', after collecting her award. Her dynamic moves, packed with emotion, was well applauded.

"I never knew Anju Bobby George was an Olympian. Got to know it just today when she was awarded. I always knew she was an outstanding athlete," said a person in the audience.

Surprisingly, for a such packed crowd, there was pin-drop silence when the awardees and their achievements were introduced and a round table discussion held with a few of them. The choice of the winners, ranging from an athlete to a handloom revivalist, perhaps caught the interest of many. The short and sweet evening concluded with delicious dinner for the invitees, truly making it a Saturday family outing.

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Bangalore, India

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Nirupama Rajendra, a Sangeet Natak Akademi awardee, is a renowned classical dancer and choreographer who has mastered Bharatanatyam and Kathak. With 35 years dedicated to her craft, she has excelled as a performer, teacher, and producer. She is the director of the Abhinava Dance Company and has delivered over 1,000 performances across five continents, reaching seven million connoisseurs. Nirupama has choreographed 200+ sequences and trained 3,000 students. Contributing to Karnataka's art and culture, Nirupama has served as an Honorary Member of Karnataka Sangeetha Nruthya Academy. She revived the ancient *Madanothsava* festival, bringing together hundreds of artists, fostering harmony and peace in the community.



NIRUPAMA RAJENDRA

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